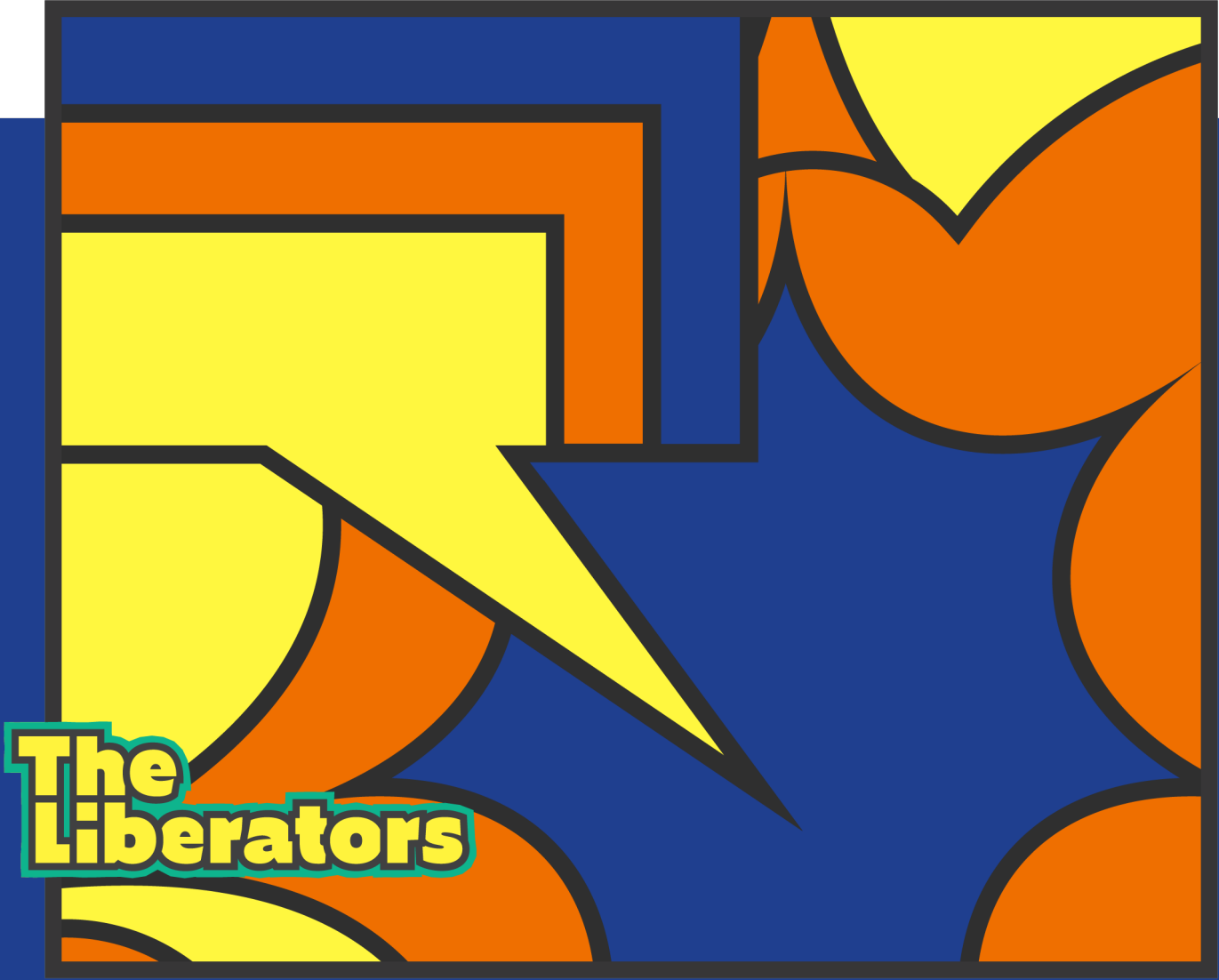


Discover How To Ship Faster With Your Team, With Future~Present

A do-it-yourself workshop that invites participants to use an outside-of-the-box perspective from the future to see what is possible today

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold, stylized shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large yellow arrow pointing right, a yellow speech bubble, and several orange and yellow curved shapes. The text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a thick black outline and a blue drop shadow, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

"If only we could travel to a future state where we are highly successful, and we could learn from the people that completed the entire journey ..."

We've all had this thought when building a complex product, launching an important initiative, or working with a completely new team. If only we could learn what was necessary in the present, in order to be successful in the future. This do-it-yourself workshop will help you learn just that. Together with your team and stakeholders, you'll uncover what is needed today, to grow into the success of tomorrow.

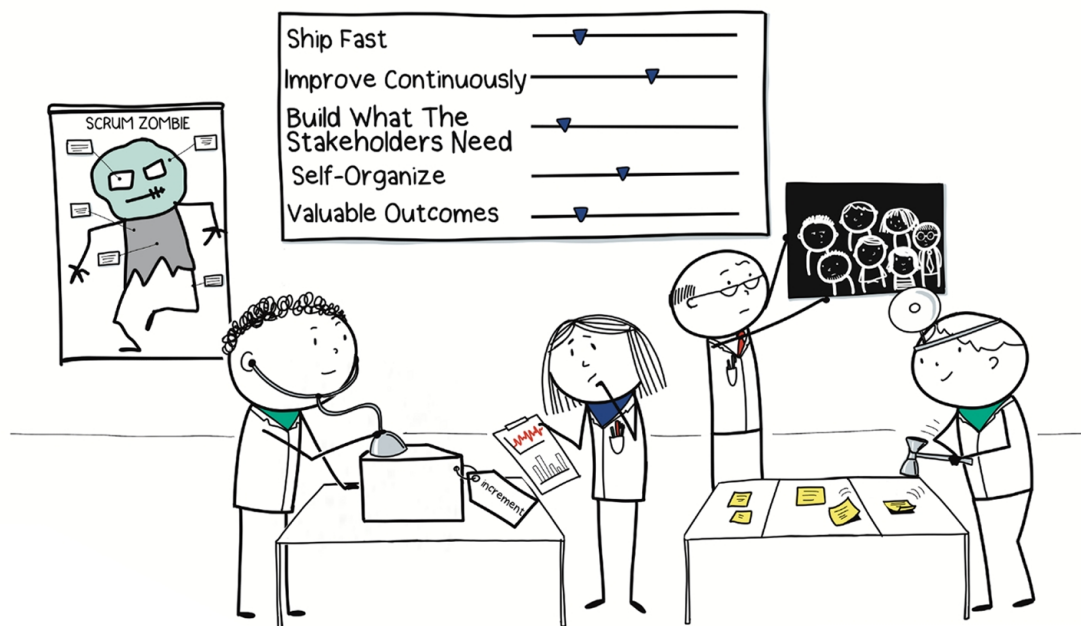
This workshop specifically focuses on your team's ability to ship faster. No matter how impossible it seems today, 25 years from now, your team managed to exceed even your wildest dreams! Your team has become the global #1 example of what it means to ship fast and deliver value to your stakeholders sooner!

Aren't you curious to learn what it took to get there? If so, run this workshop and discover it together with your team. The future is as bright as you want it to be.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify The Present State Of Shipping Fast With "5x5 Writing"

  20 min

Step 3: Travel To A Bright Future And Share What Happened With "Future~Present"

   30 min

Step 4: Decide On What To Improve With 1-2-4-ALL

  20 min

Step 5: Make Clear Requests For Help With "What I Need From You"

  45 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



If you're current situation is far from ideal, imagining a bright future might be challenging. However, the more important it is.

Impact On Survival



This workshop fuels people with hope. One of the most important feelings to survive Zombie Scrum.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 8 participants and onward, and takes about 90–120 minutes, depending on group size.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one or more Scrum teams, including the people that shape their immediate environment. In large organizations, this likely includes people from middle management positions; team managers, department managers, and HR managers. But in smaller organizations, we highly recommend including top-level management too. If you're up for it, you can certainly include more people from the environment of Scrum teams.

Virtual Delivery

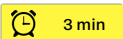
Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Ship Fast](#)



Step 1: Opening



Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Clarify The Present State Of Shipping Fast With "5x5 Writing"

Before we dive into the core structure of this workshop (Future~Present), we first give the participants an opportunity to get their thinking started about what their ability to "Ship Fast" looks like in the present. What does it mean to them? To what extent is the team or the organization capable of doing so? And what impediments make this hard?

The Liberating Structure [10x10 Writing](#) (tweaked into 5x5 writing) is a great way to loosen people up and get their thinking started. It also creates a first opportunity to connect with others.

Invitation

1. To me, shipping or releasing more frequently means ...
2. When we would ship much faster, we would ...
3. Something that would become possible for us then is to ...
4. What makes this very difficult is ...
5. If only we could ...

Steps

1. **1 min** Whether you're doing this virtually or in-person, ask everyone to sit down and take an empty piece of paper or an empty page in a notebook.
2. **2 min** Explain that you'll offer 5 sentences, one by one and that participants have a minute per sentence to write down the sentence and complete it with as many examples as they can think of. Emphasize that this is done in silence and in private.
3. **10 min** One by one, offer a sentence and wait one minute to give people time to write down as many examples as they can think of.
4. **3 min** Ask everyone to take a look at what they wrote down. Ask: "Looking back over your answers, mark patterns that immediately jump out at you".
5. **5 min** Invite people into pairs to share their notes and ideas. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.

Our Findings

- 10x10 Writing requires you to read the room. If everyone has already put their pen down, you can move to the next sentence. But also recognize that for you – as a facilitator – the timebox feels longer than for participants.



Step 3: Travel To A Bright Future And Share What Happened With "Future~Present"



While the previous step was all about the present, we're now going to invite participants to take a fresh, outside-of-the-box perspective by traveling to a potential and bright future. We use a modified version of the Liberating Structure-in-development "Future~Present".

Future~Present acknowledges the power of the kind of storytelling that humanity has engaged with since the dawn of time. Seated around a virtual campfire, it asks participants to imagine that they've traveled to a distant future where their endeavors turned out to be highly successful. Looking back from that distant future, participants work together to unravel what made that success possible and generate creative ideas for what to invest energy in today.

Invitation

"We find ourselves 25 years into a highly successful future. For all the challenges we faced in the past, shipping fast is no longer challenging today. Our organization has cultivated the skills and capabilities to release dozens of times a day without disrupting our users or causing downtime. Instead of spending months on individual releases, and wasting a lot of time and money in the process, we now test our assumptions with real users every day. Given the seemingly insurmountable challenges we faced in the past, and our miraculous journey to overcome them in the past 25 years, we are now seen as an example to our industry.

Although the veteran employees know what challenges we faced in the past, younger employees have no idea. The ability and need to release multiple times every day is as natural to them as breathing. But they are eager to learn from the veterans what made the success possible.

So we find ourselves around a warm campfire, attended both by veterans and young employees. Together, we will explore what the past looks like and what changed to make this future possible."

Steps

1. **2 min** Explain the broad idea of Future~Present, and clarify the roles of the young employees and the veterans. Invite 3 – 5 participants to become a veteran employee. Ideally, go for a mixture of team members, stakeholders, and management. Everyone else automatically becomes a young employee.
2. **2 min** If you do this in-person, create an inner circle of chairs (3 to 5). Ask the veterans to take a seat. Everyone else positions their seats in close concentric circles around the inner circle. If you do this virtually, the inner circle turns on microphones and webcams and everyone else turns theirs off.

3. **2 min** Set the tone by telling the invitation as a story. We've found it helpful to make it a bit theatrical, but maintain the serious undertone.
4. **10 min** Invite the inner circle (the veterans) to start an informal conversation about what this future looks like in as much detail as possible. Encourage the elders to improvise their answers and build on each other in a 'Yes, And...'-style. The outer circles listen and observe with full attention, take notes and remain silent throughout.
5. **5 min** Invite the "young employees" in the outer circles to form small groups (2–3 people) and use their notes to identify big questions. The "young employees" can take inspiration from the example questions below. Collect the questions so that the inner circle can use them as input for the next round. If you do this step virtually, you can form breakouts for the small groups.
6. **10 min** Invite the inner circle to go through the submitted ideas and questions in whatever order works for them. The outer circles listen and take notes, and turn off their webcam and microphone when done virtually. Continue until all submitted ideas and questions have been addressed, or until the timebox expires.

Questions For Future~Present

Although you can ask the "young employee" to improvise open questions to ask to the "veterans", we have found it helpful to hand out a set of guiding questions [by Fisher Qua](#) to find the right tone and mood for the conversation and really dig deep:

- "Veterans, we have heard about the old days, times were hard. [Expand with more details that are contextual]. There seemed to be no way out. Is it true? What problems existed? Tell us."
- "Veterans, what was it like in the midst of this turmoil? How did you feel? What gave you hope amid the despair? Tell us."
- "Veterans, there are many stories about you and your fellow pioneers, what first small steps did you take? How did you turn up the heat? How did you build and maintain momentum? Tell us."
- "Veterans, I know you did not stop with those early actions. Tell us, where did you find the strength to go on? What unusual suspects showed up that gave you hope something more was possible?"

Our Findings

- Some groups take the structure (and its conversation) quite seriously while others mostly have fun with the perspective. Both are valid and okay. Make sure to draw out enablers of success in the larger group to allow everyone to benefit from each other, while also acknowledging how ludicrous our present might be when we look at it from the future;
- Future~Present can create more urgency about what should be improved today by exposing the unspoken undercurrent. For example, we recently overheard two veterans mention how "meetings tended to take hours without any decisions". The "young employees" wondered why people even showed up, and why no one stopped this waste of time;
- If you do this in person, we highly recommend that you actually invite people to sit on the floor. For extra effect, you can turn off the lights, put on an audio-track with crickets, and ask the veterans to build a fake campfire in the middle with crumpled-up yellow stickies placed on a smartphone with its flashlight on.

Resources

- The [original article](#) about UX Fishbowl from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about User Experience Fishbowl
- Blog post: [Building Understanding Between Scrum Teams and Management with Liberating Structures](#)
- The article we wrote about [Future~Present](#)





Step 4: Decide On What To Improve With 1-2-4-ALL

With Future~Present, everyone traveled to a highly successful future, 25 years from now. In this future, all the challenges you faced around shipping fast are solved. Shipping fast is no longer a problem, your team and organization are now even seen as an example to our industry! The storytelling setting of Future~Present most likely resulted in many interesting thoughts. In this step, the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is used to identify the most important ideas from the future, the group wants to bring back into the present.

Invitation

"What actionable ideas and practical insights from the future would you like to take back to the present?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace. These ideas will become the input for the next step, "What I Need From You".

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 5: Make Clear Requests For Help With "What I Need From You"

In the previous step, the group collected the most important actionable ideas and practical insights from the future, they want to bring back to the present. In this step, it's time to explore what everyone in the room needs from each other to make the described bright future, a reality. What do the Scrum teams need from management, and stakeholders, to realize the ideas and insights? It also works the other way around; what do management and the stakeholders need from the Scrum teams?



The Liberating Structure [What I Need From You](#) is a great way to find clear answers to these questions. You may find that interactions in this structure are very direct and no-nonsense. WINFY is designed as an antidote to the diffusion of accountability that is often prevalent in organizations and makes it hard to be successful. Unclear requests for help are often met with equally unclear commitments.

Invitation

"What do you need from others in this room to increase our ability to ship faster? What do we need to change in our Definition of Done? What impediments do we need to remove?"

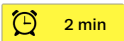
Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually write down one or more clear functional requests they have to other groups in this room. You can give some examples, like "as a Scrum team, we need management to stop changing our composition without our approval" or "as management, we need the Scrum teams to tell us openly what is impeding their work".
2. **10 min** Invite the people from the same functional groups (e.g. individual Scrum teams, management, HR) to gather. Invite them to share their ideas and write down between 3 and 5 clear functional requests they have of specific functional groups in this room ("What I need from [group], is"). If you do this virtually, move each functional group into a breakout. 3 **1 min** Ask each functional group to designate one spokesperson and gather in the middle of the room. If you're doing this virtually, everyone else can turn off their microphone and camera.
3. **10 min** One by one, each spokesperson addresses the spokesperson from another functional group they have a request for, and announce their request. For example: "From management, we need the learning budget to be doubled" or "From the Scrum team, we need one person who is willing to share these findings with higher management". When a need is addressed to a group, its spokesperson takes notes but doesn't answer. Block discussions.
4. **5 min** When every request has been made, the spokespersons return to their groups and discuss what their answer is to each request. Three responses are possible: "Yes", "No", "Huh? (We don't understand your request)".
5. **10 min** The spokespersons gather in the circle again. One by one, each of them repeats the requests that were made to them and their answer. Again, there is no discussion and no elaboration. If the answer was "No", the group asking for it can trust that their request won't happen. If it was "Yes", then the group asking it for can be certain that it will happen. If the response was "Huh?", the request was too unclear to be performed.
6. **10 min** To close this exercise, ask everyone for their 15% Solutions: "What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to help the team ship faster? What is something, or a next step, you can do that you do without

permission from other or resources you don't have access to?". Invite people into pairs to share their next steps. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.

Our Findings

- Depending on the situation you can do additional rounds of making requests and giving answers. The goal is to make (painfully) clear how crucial it is to be specific when asking for help, as unclear requests and unclear commitments are often a sign of Zombie Scrum. That's why we stop after one round. Do another round when you are certain that not being able to ask new requests causes more harm than the learning of not being able to ask again.
- Some tension during this experiment is natural as groups express clear requests and (finally) get clear answers. Recognize and accept it when it happens. Encourage participants to continue communicating their needs outside of this gathering using the same format. If a request was not understood or denied, try asking differently.
- If you see members of a group complaining about and blaming other people, ask them what it is they need specifically and whether they have communicated this need adequately.



2 min

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you traveled to a highly successful future in which all the challenges you faced in the past around shipping fast, no longer exist. You also learned what is needed today, to get there. Now that you've seen the future, it's up to you to make it happen!

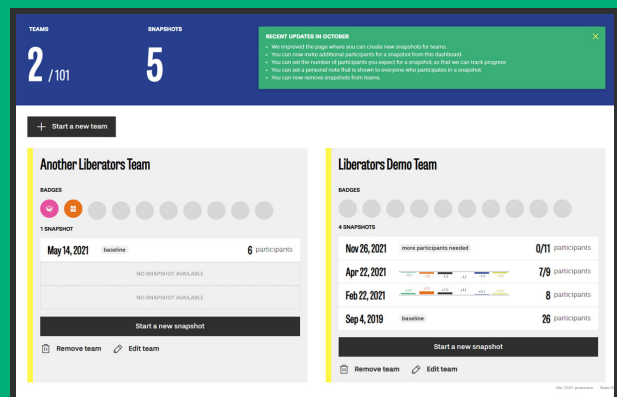
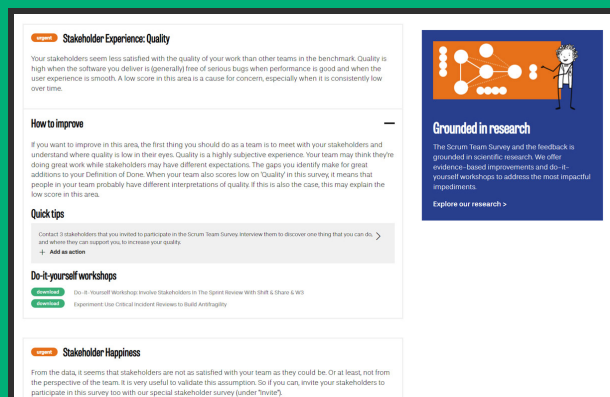
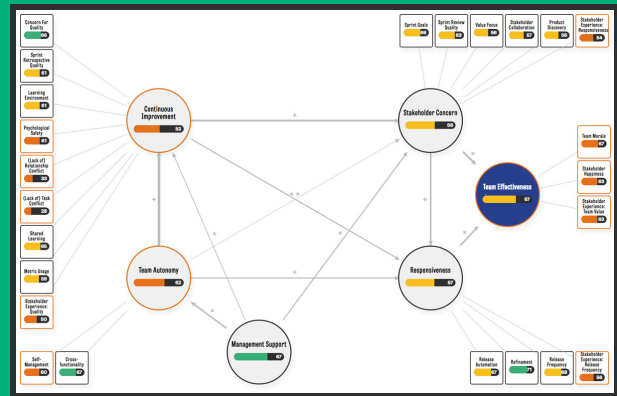
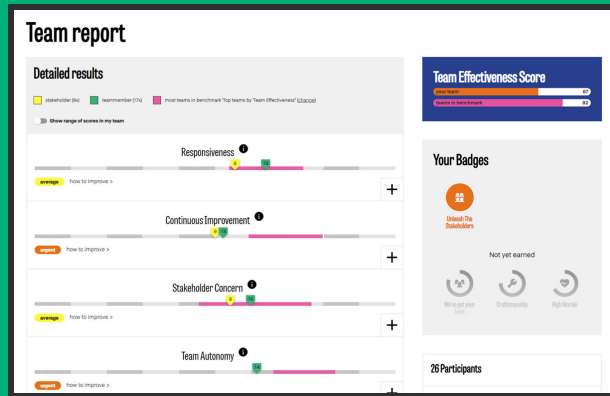
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

Supported by the community

We are super proud that The Liberators is almost entirely funded by the community. If you appreciate our work too, you can already support us for 12 dollars/year by becoming a [patron](#). In return, you gain free access to premium content, we share our work-in-progress and involve you in creating more awesome content.



Thank you for respecting our work!

We work hard to create high-quality content that puts you in a position to unleash your team. We're sure you appreciate that a lot of our time and money goes into this. At the same time, content like this is our main source of income. It's what pays our bills :)

If you purchased this content, we ask only that you treat our work with respect and don't share it with people outside your team. If you stumbled on it elsewhere without paying for it, and it offers you value, would you consider [supporting us too](#)? You can also check [out our other offerings](#).